

Think tank: Head coach Craig Fulton (right) will hope his decision-making has a definitive say in India's fortunes in what will be an increasingly competitive field. PTI

Peillat's thunderbolts from PCs, Germany has replaced them with youngsters Jakob Brilla and Benedikt Schwarzhaupt. Brilla is among the five junior World Cup winners from 2023 and 2025 in the senior squad, with the team clearly in transition, possibly with the LA Games in mind.

Germany will be kept separated from the Netherlands, which will be keen to bank on its record of reaching finals in its three previous home editions, winning two. Head coach Jeroen Delmee made his intentions clear during the squad announcement, stating, "When you play a World Championship on home soil as the current Olympic champion, you go for gold."

Roared on by a passionate home crowd, the Orange will want to unleash its fluent brand of hockey, facilitated by its suffocating full-court press and rapid transitions from defence to attack. Leading the press will be captain Thierry Brinkmann and Duco Telgenkamp in the forward line. Telgenkamp emerged as its leading scorer in the Pro League, registering the second-highest number of field goals with seven.

The Dutch will pose a serious threat from PCs, with Jip Janssen, Tijmen Reyenga and Pepijn van der Heijden adding depth. The return of midfielder Jorrit Croon and forward Thijs van Dam from injury will transform the Dutch into a formidable unit.

Australia comes into the World Cup after a mixed Pro League season, in which it started strongly before suffering five defeats in the last eight, including a heavy 6-3 loss to the Dutch. Yet, it also produced two clinical displays to down co-hosts the Netherlands and Belgium at Wavre, one of the World Cup venues.



Penalty corners will be an area of concern for the Kookaburras, whose conversion of 19 from 97 attempts was the worst among all teams.

England will be riding high on confidence and form, with Zak Jones' men scoring 54 goals and conceding just 17 during their unbeaten run in 2026. The performances culminated in a second-place finish in the Pro League with the second-best defensive record. It possesses a dynamic forward in Nicholas Bandurak, who is equally adept in both open play and PCs. Goals have been shared around, too, with Henry Croft, Sam Hooper and Sam Ward accounting for 18 goals between them.

Argentina is a potential dark horse, aiming to cash in on the

goal-scoring form of forward Tomas Domenne, who rattled in 21 goals in the Pro League. Spain is another outside contender with its all-round play, hoping to cause an upset or two.

The field for the World Cup is stronger than ever, with Europe continuing to dominate through tactical evolution, structural discipline and depth in talent. Five of the last seven World Cups have been won by a European team, and all signs point towards Europe widening its gap from the rest of the world. While India has made improvements in recent months, whether that translates into a long-awaited podium finish or serves as a platform for the higher-stakes Asian Games remains to be seen.

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